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An examination of competitive rule evolution in the National Football League

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ABSTRACT

Purpose/rationale: Competitive rules, which have implications for player safety, fairness, and entertainment, change over time, yet institutional accounts offer only a high-level view of rule change. This study centers, and looks within, competitive rules to examine how they evolve in professional sport.

Design/methodology/approach: Using an inductive approach, we conducted a qualitative document analysis of NFL rule books published between 1980 and 2020. We developed and examined longitudinal trajectories of player conduct rules.

Findings: The analysis reveals rule components (i.e. actions, actors, times, spaces, sanctions) and patterns of change. Rules generally expanded in scope and length. We draw on communications from NFL leaders to connect the findings to institutional factors.

Practical implications: The findings offer a framework for rule managers as they iterate rules to make sport safer, fairer, and more entertaining.

Research contribution: This study sheds light on how competitive rules evolve at the level of component parts, providing a foundation for future institutional scholarship on the causes and consequences of rule change.

Originality/value: This research offers a microfoundations and longitudinal understanding of rule change in sport, with insights for academics and rule managers.

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Rules; change; professional sport; institutions; document analysis

Introduction

Rules are both an essential element of sport and an aspect that changes over time. Giddens defines rules as, "techniques or generalizable procedures applied in the enactment/reproduction of social practices" (Giddens, 1984, p. 21). In sport, competitive rules (also referred to as rules of play) establish, define, and moderate behavior within games (Suits, 2007). These regulations, typically codified in rule books, govern player conduct, scoring, penalties, and other aspects of gameplay. Competitive rules also reflect the foundational principles and values of sport (McFee, 2004), with important implications for player safety, fairness, financial performance, and entertainment (Krolikowski et al., 2017; Mastromarco & Runkel, 2009; Vamplew, 2007). For example, many leagues have rules to reduce "tanking" (deliberately losing), which can erode the integrity and excitement of the game (Kendall & Lenten, 2017). Sport leagues and governing bodies regularly modify their competitive rules. These changes can range from introducing new rules to removing rules but are more commonly smaller alterations to words or phrases (e.g. the

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distance increase of a point after a touchdown attempt in the NFL moving incrementally further away from the target goal posts). The aim of this study is to provide an account of rule change that reflects adjustments over time. We address the question: how do competitive rules evolve in professional sport?

This study extends from research on the institutional dynamics of rule change. Scholarship in this area suggests that sport organizations are compelled to change rules of play due to institutional forces stemming from new information or technology, salient events, or shifting preferences (e.g. around concussions or athlete compensation) (Heinze & Lu, 2017; Nite, 2017; Parent & O'Brien, 2018). However, competitive rule change is often only one element within researchers' broader examination of institutional forces (O'Brien & Slack, 2004; Skirstad & Chelladurai, 2011). With rules not the primary focus, we get a high-level view of change that implicitly assumes binary possibilities (i.e. modified or not) at limited moments in time. For example, Riehl et al. (2021) examined a failed attempt at rule change (i.e. not adopted) around cross-ice play in youth hockey.

Rarely are rules in sport adopted or rejected wholesale at one point in time and never iterated again. Indeed, historical perspectives suggest that the evolution of rules in sport is characterized by repeated iterations over time (Guttmann, 2004). These retrospective accounts often reference the professionalization process in the initial formalization and codification of rules (O'Brien & Slack, 2004), but competitive rules are regularly modified beyond this stage. As a more recent example, the chop block in the NFL underwent repeated changes over time until it was finally banned prior to the 2016 season (NFL, 2016c). Such alterations are not typically accounted for in institutional research on competitive rules, limiting our understanding of how rules change in already highly professionalized, formalized organizations.

In this study, we examine how competitive rules evolve in the context of professional sport with a longitudinal, qualitative study of NFL rules. Data come from NFL rule books from the 1980 through 2020 seasons, with a focus on player conduct rules that regulate high-impact plays. Our analysis reveals components of rules, changes to those components, and trends in how rules evolved. To contextualize our findings and discuss practical implications for leaders, we draw on public NFL communications regarding the observed rule changes; these point to the role of institutional factors, such as norms and expectations around health and safety, player behavior, and officiating quality. This study contributes to the literature on rule change in sport (Cocchiarella & Edwards, 2020; Dowling et al., 2021) by identifying how competitive rules evolve as elements are modified, and tracing changes to institutional influences. Our research also offers a methodological approach for future work.

Theoretical framework

Institutional theory posits that organizations within an institutional field, such as professional sport, comply with normative, regulative, and cultural-cognitive demands to secure and maintain legitimacy (Scott, 2001). For example, professional sport leagues in the United States implemented new policies as they faced social pressure to address player conduct within and outside the game (Ugolini, 2007; Wilson, 2010). One way organizations respond to institutional forces is through the creation and modification of rules (Edelman, 1992; Ocasio, 1999). For example, Heinze and Lu (2017) traced rule changes related to player safety in the NFL to new research and mounting normative pressure to address concussions. Nite (2017) also found that the National Collegiate Athletic Association (NCAA) altered eligibility rules in response to threats from regulative challenges around the compensation of college athletes.

Sport organizations do not just conform to existing institutional standards, however, they

play an active role in creating, maintaining, and disrupting institutions (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006). This institutional work can involve rule management. Research suggests that sport organizations and entities (e.g. student athlete unions, concussion coalitions, IOC) may adjust rules as part of larger efforts meant to change (Lu & Heinze, 2021), preserve (Dowling et al., 2021), or disrupt institutions (Cocchiarella & Edwards, 2020). However, rules tend to present as one component of those broader efforts, instead of the central unit of analysis. For example, in Nite's (2017) study of NCAA efforts to preserve institutional positioning, messaging around rule change was just one aspect of the organization's strategic framing.

We argue that enhancing knowledge of rule evolution in sport requires centering and looking within rules to detect changes in words and phrases over an extended timeframe. This lens aligns with a microfoundations approach to institutional scholarship that suggests we can better understand the evolution of sport as a macro institution by examining micro-level organizational elements (Robertson et al., 2021). For instance, we can learn more about how sport governing bodies respond to institutional pressures to address player safety by looking beneath high-level shifts in the field to adjustments that are happening locally and incrementally. Insight into competitive rule change at the level of component parts can provide a valuable foundation for research parsing the institutional influences on sport organizations. This knowledge can allow scholars and practitioners to explore whether changes to particular aspects of rules address institutionally relevant goals.

Rule change in the NFL

Historical and sociological perspectives demonstrate the complexity around the formalization and institutionalization of sport, including the influences of quantification and commodification (Frey & Eitzen, 1991; Guttmann, 1988). A significant aspect of this process was the establishment of standardized rules, and eventually, an intense regulation of sport (Bruyninckx, 2012). In American football, rules started to become more formalized at the beginning of the twentieth century, as leaders grappled with player deaths and the commercial potential of the game (Crepeau, 2020). Sport governing bodies, such as the NFL, continue to modify rules, and have developed organizational structures to manage this process, as they contend with persistent and novel institutional challenges.

Since 1968, rule changes in the NFL have been managed by the league's Competition Committee (NFL, 2021). Members come from different organizational positions, including president, general manager, owner, and head coach. The membership regularly turns over. However, the current chair, Rich McKay, was appointed 30 years ago, becoming chairman in 2011 (NFL, 2011; Stroud, 1993). The committee uses five criteria to evaluate possible rule changes (NFL, 2023): Does the change improve the game? How will it be officiated? How will it be coached? Can the player apply the rule on the field? Does the change enhance player protection? The final criterion was added prior to the 2018 season, likely due to pressure to address head injuries, given new evidence around long-term impacts, and increased ability to detect injuries (Mack et al., 2021). The other criteria reflect more consistent demands and goals related to game quality (i.e. officiating accuracy, player achievement).

Following each season, the committee collects feedback on rules from, "a variety of sources," including player surveys, meetings with stakeholders, injury data, and video footage (NFL, 2021). Then, the committee proposes rule changes and corresponding reports specifying rationale. Proposals are shared with franchise owners at the annual meeting. For a rule change to go into effect, 75 percent of the owners must support the proposal. NFL rules are codified in rule books updated each

year. In this study, we focused on a subset of highly salient player conduct rules that address behaviors, such as types of blocks, dangerous hits, and player protections. The purpose of this research is to provide a nuanced account of competitive rule change in professional sport that reflects incremental iterations over time. We pursue the following corresponding objectives.

1. Investigate changes to a group of competitive rules in sport.
2. Identify internal elements of competitive rules that are repeatedly modified.
3. Explore trends in, and patterns of, rule change over time.
4. Connect observed changes to institutional factors.

Methods

We employed a qualitative document analysis (QDA) to investigate how competitive rules evolve in sport. QDA involves the systematic examination and interpretation of textual sources to derive meaningful insights (Bowen, 2009; Kang & Svensson, 2021). This methodology is appropriate for this study where information is contained within documents (Bekker & Posbergh, 2022). A strength of QDA is being able to trace, "change and development," (Bowen, 2009, p. 30), making it well suited to this project.

Data collection

The data source for player conduct rules was the NFL rule books spanning 40 years: 1980–2020. We downloaded publicly available rule books from websites, such as the NFL's operations and communications pages (NFL, 2022b, 2022a). Older rule books were obtained from the Pro Football Hall of Fame in Canton, Ohio. In total, we collected 35 complete sets of rule books. Missing were rule books from the 1990, 1991, 2004, 2005, 2007, and 2008 seasons. A description of how those were accounted for is provided below. To contextualize the findings, we draw on information from the NFL's communications website, including transcripts from press conferences and media calls with league leaders regarding rule changes. This information was leveraged to discuss factors that may explain the findings, explore implications for leaders, and offer directions for future research.

Data analysis

We adopted an inductive approach to generate new insights about rule change in sport (Gioia et al., 2013). The analysis was an iterative process that involved visiting and revisiting data to develop meaningful codes (Srivastava & Hopwood, 2009). Multiple researchers conducted the coding, with regular meetings to discuss emerging codes. Thus, the procedure included analyst triangulation, helping minimize biases and increasing confidence in the findings (Patton, 2002). Our approach also involved the use of analytical memos, a qualitative tool for recording researcher insights and interpretations (Bengtsson, 2016).

First, player conduct rules were reviewed to develop familiarity with their structure and substance. Rules are organized by article within the player conduct section. We refer to these articles as "rules" (the term commonly applied). This was the unit of analysis. To trace rule changes, we constructed rule trajectories. Trajectories allow researchers to compare across instances of the unit of analysis and build support and robustness around the findings (Soderstrom & Weber, 2020). The trajectories tracked changes made to each of the following player conduct rules during the observation period: unsportsmanlike conduct, unnecessary roughness, roughing the passer, chop blocking, crackback blocking, and clipping. This sample of rules was selected to capture a variety of game events.

To generate the trajectories, we developed a data preparation process to produce a record of changes made to the rules. Scanned copies of rules were converted to text documents.

Then, we used the "compare documents" feature within Microsoft Word (2022) to create a document that specified alterations made to the rule through formatting updates. Initially, we considered two-year intervals (e.g. 1980 vs. 1981), but these did not contain substantial changes. Thus, we used five-year comparative intervals (e.g. 1980–1985) for each of the six rule trajectories. When a rule book was not available for a year, we substituted one from the year before or after. Once comparative documents were made for each trajectory, we began coding. The first step was to determine what qualified as a change. A rule change was defined as an alteration in the language of the rule that could affect its enforcement. Changes that satisfied the definition ranged from alternations of single words to additions of new articles. We disregarded formatting changes and reorganization.

Next, we identified the core of the rule change (what was changed about the on-field regulation) in objective terms. For example, if the yards awarded following a violation increased, the change was articulated as, "Expands the sanction for violating the rule." We captured the core of each change across the observation period for all trajectories, and coded these, guided by our interest in rule evolution. We generated first-order codes (Gioia et al., 2013) (e.g. actions, expansion). Continuing with the previous example, "Expands the sanctions for violating the rule" contains two codes for expansion and sanctions. As we progressed, we identified two higher-order categories: rule components and types of change. Once the full coding scheme was developed, we went back through the data, applying the coding scheme systematically.

In the next step, we analyzed how rule components and types of change evolved over time. This process started with examining individual trajectories, reviewing the coded text by components and change type over the years of the study. We identified similar patterns across trajectories in both how rule components and types of change evolved, therefore we aggregated the coded text for each rule component and change type across trajectories using NVivo (QSR International Pty Ltd., 2020). We went through each component and change type, reviewing the aggregated coded text for that component and change type over time. This allowed us to identify overall trends in how rules changed by component and rule change type. We also tracked the word count of rules over time to provide additional insight into how rules evolve. Figure 1 provides a diagram of the steps in the analytical process. Figure 2 offers an example of the analytical process for two rule changes.

Findings and discussion

The analysis reveals that player conduct rules in the NFL tended to grow over time in scope and length. More actions were accounted for and prohibited, more actors were protected and prohibited from acting, rules applied in more game moments and spaces, and the severity of sanctions tended to increase. Although there was a sequence to their evolution that included a reduction phase, rules were longer at the end of the period compared with the beginning. These findings suggest that the NFL was trying to regulate more aspects of the game over time. We discuss and contextualize these findings in the following sections, starting with how the rule components changed.[1]

Trends in rule components

We identified five components of competitive rules in the NFL that were manipulated in the

[1]We denote rule changes with text formatting. Underlined text represents new content added to a rule. Crossed out text represents content removed from a rule.

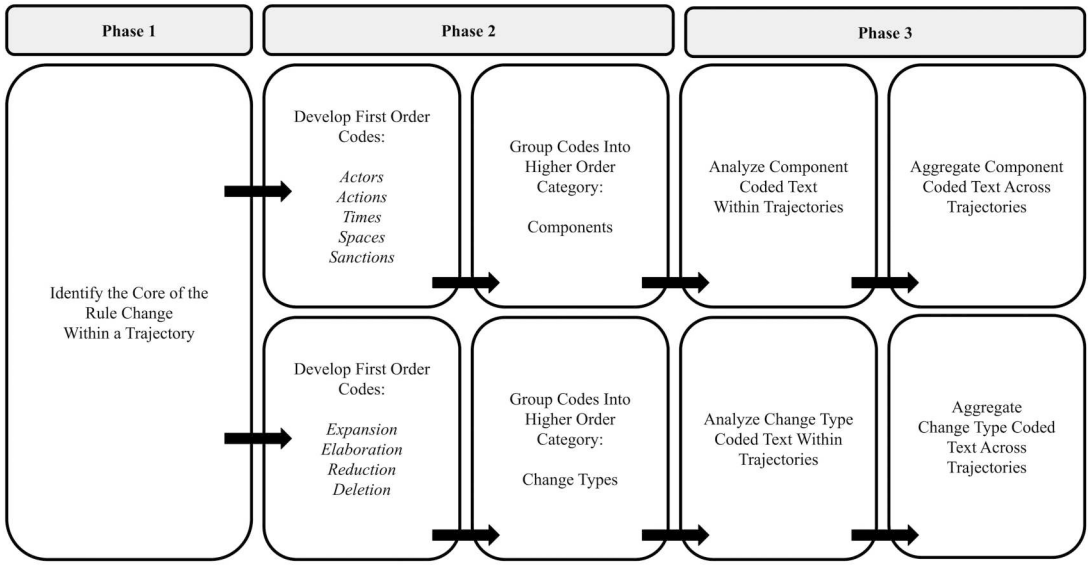

Figure 1. Overview of coding and analysis process.

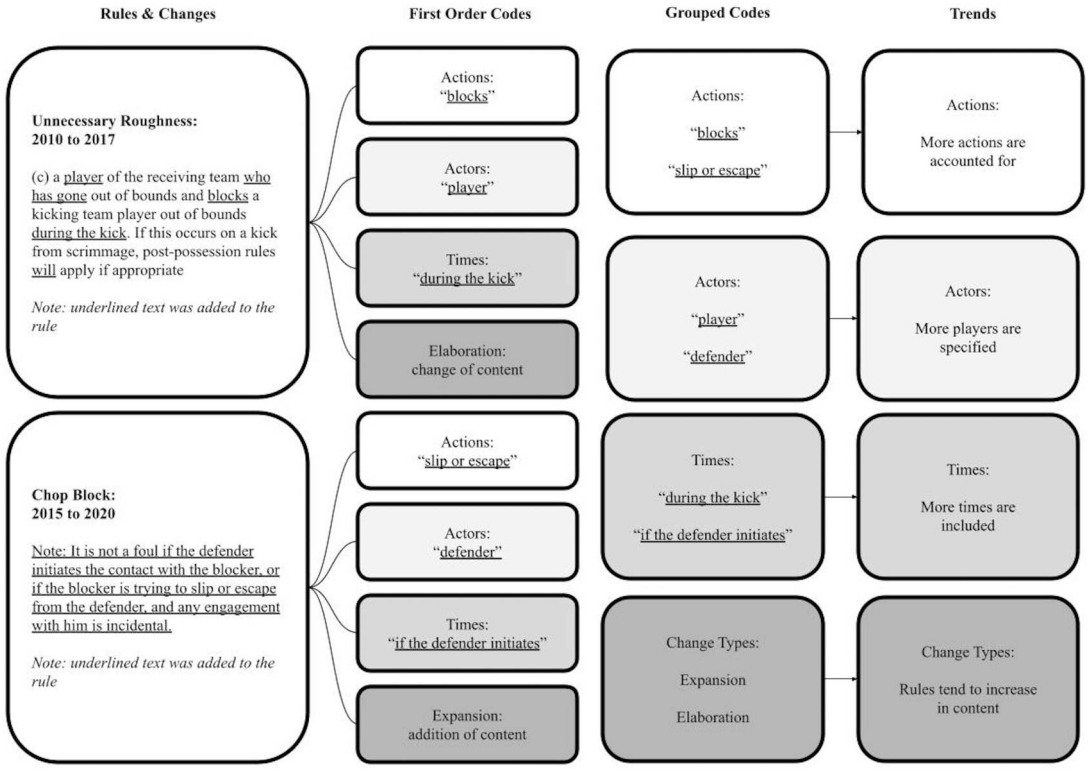

Figure 2. Example of coding and analysis process.

course of rule changes: actions, actors, times, spaces, and sanctions. Some rule changes affected one component; others altered multiple components. Rule changes that manipulated actions altered the permissibility of a specific game-related action (e.g. tackles, blocks, celebrations, taunting). Rule changes affecting actors adjusted protections, permissions, or prohibitions applied to categories of players (e.g. offense, defense, special teams, positions) and personnel (e.g. referees, coaches, side line members). Rule changes that manipulated the spaces component altered the areas in which a rule applied, including competitive spaces on the field (e.g. the tackle box), spaces off the field (e.g. out of bounds), and corporeal spaces of players' bodies and uniforms. Changes affecting the times component altered the moments in which a rule applied, including intra-game moments such as specific downs, as well as moments outside of the game. Rule changes that altered sanctions adjusted the penalty for breaking a rule. Table 1 summarizes the five components and offers examples of rule changes. Next, we discuss how rules changed over time along each of these components.

Actions

We found that rule changes concerning the *actions* component tended to increase the set of actions accounted for and prohibited by the rules. The chop block and crackback block trajectories are useful examples, with some of the changes reflected in the text below. At the beginning of the observation period, the rule changes affecting the chop block and crackback block tended to provide more nuanced accounts of both actions. In both cases, the initial rule changes clarified what kinds of actions were permitted and prohibited. Later in the observation period, the changes tended to further prohibit actions. For example, as reflected in the data below, eventually, chop blocks and crackback blocks were fully disallowed. Rule changes involving the *actions* component tended to create greater restrictions on various game-related acts over time.

Chop block rule change between 1989 and 1995:

> (4) On a forward pass play, ~~A1 fires out aggressively and~~ A1 blocks a defensive player in the area of the thigh or lower, and A2, simultaneously or immediately after the block by A1, engages the defensive player high.

Crackback block rule change between 1989 and 1995:

> *Note 2: If runner (passer) scrambles on the play, significantly changing the original direction (broken play), the crackback block is legal.*

Chop block rule change between 2015 and 2020:

> ARTICLE ~~3~~ 5. CHOP BLOCK. All Chop Blocks are illegal. A Chop Block is a high/low double-team block by the offense in which one offensive player (designated as A1 for purposes of this rule) blocks a defensive player in the area of the thigh or lower while another offensive player (A2) engages that same defensive player above the waist. The order of the blocks is irrelevant.

Crackback block change between 2015 and 2020:

> ARTICLE ~~2. ILLEGAL6.~~ CRACKBACK BLOCK. ~~It is an Illegal~~ All Crackback Blocks are illegal.
>
> Item 1. Definition. It is a Crackback Block ~~if a defensive player is contacted below~~ the ~~waist~~ following conditions are fulfilled: The block occurs within an area five yards on either side of the line of scrimmage, including within close-line play, by an offensive player who is moving toward the position from which the ball was snapped, and …

Actors

We found that rule changes concerning the *actors* component tended to either protect more people from actions or prohibit more people from exhibiting actions. Protections were added in different ways. One way was to further describe the contextual conditions which rendered a player protected. An

Table 1. Definitions and examples of components.

Component	Description	Example(s)
Actions	Directly affects the permissibility of a specific game-related action	(c) ~~Any prolonged, excessive~~ Unnecessary physical contact with a game official. (Unsportsmanlike Conduct – 1989–1996)
Actors	Directly involves the protection of a game-related actor, a prohibition applied to a game-related actor, or a permission granted to a game-related actor	(1) The Rules Committee is definitely committed to the policy of protecting the ~~passer~~ quarterback. Officials are to blow the play dead as soon as the quarterback is clearly in the grasp and control of any tackler behind the line. (Roughing the Passer – 1985–1989)
Times	Relates to moments in which a rule applies	~~(5) On a running play,~~ (2) Each of the above circumstances, which describes a chop block foul on a kicking play, also applies on a play in which an offensive player indicates an apparent attempt to kick protect, but the play ultimately becomes a run (Chop Block – 1989–1996)
Spaces	Relates to the areas in which a rule applies	(e) A1 is lined up in the backfield at the snap and subsequently chops a defensive player engaged above the waist by A2~~, and such block occurs on or behind the line of scrimmage in an area extending laterally to the positions originally occupied by the tight end on either side.~~ (Chop Block – 2010–2015)
Sanctions	Involves the adjustment of the penalty for violating a rule	Penalty: For Roughing the Passer: Loss of 15 yards ~~from the previous spot~~ and an automatic first down; disqualification, if flagrant. (Roughing the Passer – 2010–2015)

Note: Underlined text represents additions to the rule and strike-through text represents deletions.

example of this kind of change took place in the unnecessary roughness rule between 2000 and 2006. As illustrated below, additional language was included to specify that a player who "should not have reasonably anticipated such contact" was protected from that contact. Descriptions such as these increase the protections for players who meet that contextual criterion. Because the newly added description supplements a previous one (out of the play) the change enlarged the total pool of players protected by the rule. This reinforced the general trend of an increase in game-related events accounted for by rules.

Unnecessary roughness change between 2000 and 2006:

> (e) unnecessarily running ~~or~~, diving into, cutting, or throwing the body against or on a player ~~obviously~~ who (i) is out of the play or (ii) should not have reasonably anticipated such contact by an opponent, before or after the ball is dead; or throwing the runner to the ground after the ball is dead

Rule changes also increased protections for players by attaching a descriptive label to them that conferred protections, similar to that of protected classes or groups in modern employment legislation. A common protective label in NFL rule books was "defenseless player." Below is an example of this label added to the Crackback Block rule between 2010 and 2015.

Crackback block change between 2010 and 2015:

> (2) A player who is protected from a crackback block is also a defenseless player (see Article 7).

By adding the label of "defenseless player," a violation of the rule invoked other sanctions. Specifically, contacting "Players in a Defenseless Posture" resulted in a loss of 15 yards, an automatic first down, and possible disqualification if the act was deemed to be sufficiently flagrant (NFL, 2015a, pp. 50–51). Adding the label of "defenseless player" dilated the protections and sanctions afforded to qualified actors in the game.

The analysis also indicates that rule changes involving actors tended to expand who is

prohibited from exhibiting actions. Reflected below, changes to roughing the passer involved an extension of which defenders were prohibited from specific kinds of tackles. By adjusting the description of the defenders who were prohibited from hitting the passer in a specific area, more defenders were potentially implicated by the prohibition.

Roughing the passer change between 2000 and 2006:

> A rushing defender ~~who has an unrestricted path to the passer from any direction~~ is prohibited from forcibly hitting the ~~passer in the~~ knee area or below of a passer who has one or both fee on the ground, even if the initial contact is above the knee. It is not a foul if the defender is blocked (or fouled) into the passer and has no opportunity to avoid him

By removing the stipulation that the defender must have a free lane to the passer, more types of defenders in a larger variety of possible game dynamics were prohibited from tackling the passer low.

Spaces

We discovered that rule changes in the NFL tended to increase the spaces in which the rules apply. Changes to the *spaces* component within rules increased the application of those rules to areas of play and areas of a player's body. Areas of a player's body (including uniform) can represent vulnerable parts to be protected, or potentially dangerous ones used while playing the game. A change to the unnecessary roughness rule prohibiting aggressive strikes with the leg addressed both relevancies of a player's body. In the change below, the area protected and the area prohibited from use both increased by removing the specification of striking the opponent "above the knee" with a part of the leg "below the knee." More spaces in general were thus implicated by the rule after the change.

Unnecessary roughness change between 2006 and 2010:

> (a) striking an opponent anywhere ~~above the knee~~ with the foot or any part of the leg ~~below the knee~~ with a whipping motion;

The analysis also indicates that rule changes resulted in prohibitions that apply within more competitive spaces (e.g. field of play, bench, tunnel). Often, the relevant space was determined by the scope of the rule in question. The progression of the rule prohibiting intentional fouls to prevent scoring demonstrates the trend we observed concerning the spaces component. The rule's instantiation depended on where fouls occurred relative to the defense's goal line. Initially, the prohibitions against intentional fouls only applied when the foul occurred close to the endzone. The special requirement was changed to increase the area of the field where the prohibition applies, expanding the areas in which the defense can be penalized for committing "successive or continued fouls," to prevent the other team from scoring. This example aligns with the overarching finding that rule changes to space, corporeal or competitive, were expansionary.

Unsportsmanlike conduct change between 1992 and 1996:

> Article 2 The defense, when near its goal line, shall not commit successive or continued fouls (half distance penalties) to prevent a score.

Unsportsmanlike conduct change between 2000 and 2006:

> Article 2 The defense~~, when near its goal line,~~ shall not commit successive or continued fouls ~~(half distance penalties)~~ to prevent a score.

Times

Our analysis suggests that changes to the *times* component often made the rule apply to more game moments. Those moments included intra-play time during a game and time outside a specific play of the game. An example of a rule change from the roughing

the passer rule demonstrates an alteration to intra-play time. The change, documented below, extended protections for passers through the end of the play after a possession change, even when such a possession change renders the quarterback a defender of his own endzone.

Roughing the passer change between 2000 and 2006:

> A passer who is standing or still or fading backwards after the ball has left his hand is obviously out of the play and must not be unnecessarily contacted by the defense through the end of the play or until the passer becomes a blocker, or until he becomes a runner upon taking a lateral from a teammate or picking up a loose ball, or, in the event of a change of possession on the play, until the passer, assumes a distinctly defensive position. An opponent may not unnecessarily initiate helmet-to-helmet contact to the quarterback at any time after the possession changes.

Rule changes to the *times* component also rendered rules applicable before and after the game. In the following example, the updated prohibitions of a rule applied outside the temporal confines of a game. The addition of the note, provided below, meant players could be penalized before and after the game for certain conduct. The change implied that there are expectations of conduct that follow players beyond competitive times and spaces. There are obvious limits to the growth of when a rule can apply, but during our observation period, rule changes to the times component reflected expansion.

Unsportsmanlike conduct change between 1992 and 1996:

> Note: Violations of (a) or (b) (above), which occur before or during the game may result in disqualification in addition to the yardage penalty. Any violations at the game site on the day of the game, including postgame, may result in discipline by the Commissioner. Any violation of (c) (above) results in disqualification and also will include discipline by the Commissioner.

Sanctions

The analysis reveals that the *sanctions* component of rules in the NFL remained relatively stable compared to other components. Changes to sanctions tended to be smaller and less frequent than modifications to other components. When sanctions were altered, the changes increased the severity, or the cost applied to the rule-breaking team or awarded to the other team as a result. The severity of sanctions was increased through the addition of yardage associated with the penalty, provision of automatic first downs because of the infraction, awarding a score, and ejection. Below are examples of changes to the severity of sanctions across different rule trajectories.

Unnecessary roughness change between 1989 and 1996:

> Penalty: For unnecessary roughness: Loss of 15 yards. The player may be disqualified if the action is judged by the official(s) to be flagrant.
>
> *Note: If in doubt about a roughness call or potentially dangerous tactics, the covering official(s) should always call unnecessary roughness*.

Roughing the passer change between 2010 and 2015:

> Penalty: For roughing the passer: Loss of 15 yards ~~from the previous spot~~ and an automatic first down; disqualification, if flagrant.

Unsportsmanlike conduct change between 1992 and 1996:

> Penalty: For continuous fouls to prevent a score: if the violation is repeated after a warning, the score involved is awarded to the offensive team.

Trends in types of rule change

The analysis also suggests that NFL rules tended to expand and grow in length over time. We discovered four main change types: expansion, elaboration, reduction, and deletion. Rule changes involved at least one of the

following: an expansion of the rule by adding text, elaboration of the rule by adjusting text, reduction of the content of the rule by removing text, or deletion of the rule altogether. Table 2 provides a description and example of each.

The overall trend regarding these change types was that rules tended to expand. This finding aligns with the length of rules. The total word content of the rules we analyzed grew from 1473 to 3700 between 1980 and 2020. Individual rules, however, proceeded through a more nuanced evolution. We found that specific rule trajectories generally underwent a sequence of changes that included expansion of content, followed by elaboration, and then reduction of content. There was only one rule deletion. Even with this sequence, individual rules tended to be longer at the end of our observation period, compared with the beginning (i.e. the reductions in content were not substantial enough to offset earlier expansions of text), which contributed to an overall trend of rule growth.

Table 2. Definitions and examples of change types.

Change Type	Definition	Example(s)
Expansion	Significant addition of content, as a new rule or to an extant rule, that initially accounts for game-related events	(c) Any prolonged, excessive, or premeditated celebration by individual players or groups of players will be construed as unsportsmanlike conduct. (Unsportsmanlike Conduct – 1980–1985)
Elaboration	The changing of existing rule content or slight addition of content that increases the game-related events accounted for	(d) running, diving into, or throwing the body against or on a runner whose forward progress has been stopped, who has slid, or who has declared himself down by going to the ground untouched and has made no attempt to advance (Unnecessary Roughness – 2015–2020)
Reduction	The reduction in content of the rule that further increases the game-related events accounted for (generalization)	(b) ~~tackling the~~ contacting a runner ~~when he is clearly~~ out of bounds (Unnecessary Roughness – 2006–2010)
Deletion	The complete removal of rule content (Note: does not include the movement of a rule – reorganization)	~~(d) A defensive player is prohibited from clubbing the arm of a passer during a pass or just after a pass has been thrown; however, a defensive player may grasp, pull, or otherwise make normal contact with a passer's arm in attempting to tackle him.~~ (Roughing the Passer – 2015–2020)

Note: Underlined text represents additions to the rule and strike-through text represents deletions.

The roughing the passer rule provides an example of a rule proceeding through the pattern of change types we discovered. This rule expanded between 1989 and 1995 from 419 to 1,096 words.

Roughing the passer expansion between 1989 and 1995:

> Because the act of passing often puts the quarterback (or any other player attempting a pass) in a position where he is particularly vulnerable to injury, special rules against roughing the passer apply. The referee has principal responsibility for enforcing these rules. Any physical acts against passers during or just after a pass which, in the referee's judgment, are unwarranted by the circumstances of the play will be called as fouls. The referee will be guided by the following principles:

Our analysis suggests the rule was elaborated for 15 years, reaching a content peak in 2010 at 1,189 words.

Roughing the passer elaboration between 2010 and 2015:

> Because the act of passing often puts the quarterback (or any other player attempting a pass) in a position where he is particularly vulnerable to injury, special rules against roughing the passer apply. The Referee has principal responsibility for enforcing these rules. Any physical acts against a player who is in a passing posture (i.e. before, during, or after a

> pass) which, in the Referee's judgment, are unwarranted by the circumstances of the play will be called as fouls. The Referee will be guided by the following principles:

Finally, it was reduced between 2010 and 2020 to 1,087 words, which was notably longer than the initial year analyzed.

Institutional contextualization of rule changes

The finding that rules tended to grow in scope and length suggests the NFL tried to regulate more over time, through modifying different rule components. This rule growth may be due to several factors identified in prior institutional research and evident in NFL communications. One relevant influence is widespread concern for player health and safety in sport. Previous research indicates that the NFL responded to new knowledge and pressure around concussions through organizational changes (Heinze & Lu, 2017). The finding that rules tended to account for more actions within the game and remove certain types of techniques aligns with language from the Competition Committee around player safety. Members and advisors of the committee reported that they wanted to get certain types of actions "out of the game," such as using the head when tackling (NFL, 2017, 2019). Similarly, the discovery that the NFL's rule changes protected and prohibited more actors is consistent with the league's reasoning related to safety. Commissioner Goodell stated that one of the goals when changing rules is, "trying to protect defenseless players" (NFL, 2018).

Changes to the spaces component may have complemented adjustments to the actions and actors components in addressing player safety. The finding that rule changes increased the spaces in which rules apply aligns with rationale from the NFL. When questioned about prohibiting the use of the crown of the helmet when tackling and hits to the lower body of the quarterback, Goodell stated, "the rule changes are safety related … on the use of the crown of the helmet that was a clarification I would consider being a rule change. And the other was low hits to the quarterback" (NFL, 2016c). Extending the spaces where rules apply was explicitly referenced when the league made changes to the rule prohibiting horse collar tackles in the 2016 offseason. NFL Players Association president Troy Vincent said, "What we did there is just expand the language that will now include the nameplate as an area that the players cannot actually grab now" (NFL, 2016a).

Another possible explanation for the overarching finding that NFL rules tended to grow in scope and length is increasing social attention and pressure to manage the behavior of players. The NFL faced public scrutiny after multiple episodes of domestic violence by players across the years of this study (Gotberg & Wiersma-Mosley, 2022). Further, the advent and rise of social media fueled attention to, and fan interaction with, players (MacPherson & Kerr, 2021). League perspectives on alterations to the times component suggest the expansion of moments in which rules applied may be due, in part, to the NFL's efforts to foster player behavior that is respectable, especially as NFL players are potential role models (Rorke & Copeland, 2017). During a 2016 press conference, McKay stated the following regarding the unsportsmanlike conduct rule adjustments making the rule enforceable in a greater amount of game moments: "As the college representative at our Competition Committee meeting said to us, the way our [NFL] players conduct themselves is the way their [collegiate] players want to conduct themselves" (NFL, 2016b). This statement implies influence between professional sports and other levels (e.g. collegiate, youth).

Changes to the sanctions component of rules may also reflect attention to the nature of play. We found that the NFL increased the

penalties associated with specific rule violations over time. These adjustments were consistent with efforts to preserve quality of play by addressing player conduct rules. For example, the NFL changed the criteria necessary for a player to be ejected from a game, which is the most severe in-game sanction. During the owners' meeting in 2016, the NFL announced that two violations of unsportsmanlike conduct rules would result in an ejection (NFL, 2016a). Moreover, the league empowered officials to eject sideline personnel if officials deemed a single violation of the unsportsmanlike conduct rule to be sufficiently flagrant (NFL, 2016a).

A third factor that may have informed rule change is officiating quality, tied to the institutional values of fairness and entertainment in professional sport (Gill, 2016; Watson, 2013). However, this aspect could be in tension with local issues related to increasing rule scope and length. The NFL's former Head of Officiating, Dean Blandino, stated that a goal of the league when changing rules is to "allow for greater consistency" and "make it simpler to [officials]" (NFL, 2016b). Rules that are easier to enforce may help referees avoid situations in which they are perceived as biasing the outcome (Raab et al., 2021). Goodell explained that repeated and incremental "clarification of rules" can improve the quality of officiating, and by extension, the quality of the game (NFL, 2015b). However, the finding that rules expanded in scope and length suggests that there may be a paradox here, with implications for leaders: changes to individual rules may be aimed at improving clarity, but the overall growth of rules could increase the cognitive load for officials (i.e. make remembering and enforcement more difficult). Perhaps this is why rules tended to go through eventual reductions in content. The NFL may have tried to achieve greater rule parsimony to improve officiating.

The repeated iteration of rule components, and the overall growth in the scope, appears to connect to different practical challenges NFL leaders experience in managing sport. Notably, Goodell stated that rule changes, "go in increments" and those increments are a product of "trying to deal with a particular issue" but that the rule will inevitably "evolve into something that will incorporate other issues" (NFL, 2016c). As we discuss below, future research can explore these dynamics further, building on our work to offer additional insights for rule managers.

Implications, limitations, and future directions

Our study, and its limitations, have implications for sport management researchers and practitioners. In identifying the components of rules that were iterated in the NFL, and how they evolved, this study offers a framework for scholars and professionals addressing rule change in sport. We suggest the components (i.e. actions, actors, times, spaces, and sanctions) represent what sport organizations can alter when changing rules. However, this research focused on American football and a particular section of rules. Thus, the findings may be most applicable to player conduct-type rules in other physical, contact sports in the U.S.

To expand on our work, scholars should examine other types of rules (e.g. non-player conduct, game definitions) managed by governing bodies (e.g. NCAA, IOC) across different types and levels of sport worldwide. For example, in youth sport, where the rules are often adapted from (inter)national governing bodies, the sanctions component may be iterated to a lesser degree since the focus is on long-term skill development (Garcia-Angulo et al., 2020). Further, our study explored rule change in the NFL's post-professionalization period. Future research can examine rule modification at an earlier stage, such as with esports that is still undergoing institutionalization (Pizzo et al., 2019). Scholars can use our

tailored methodological approach to examine how rules evolve in other sport contexts, providing insight around the generalizability, and potential boundary conditions, of our findings.

Additionally, our study did not systematically analyze the causes and consequences of rule change. Future work can link the components we identified to organizational goals related to institutional concerns (e.g. player safety, fairness, entertainment) or internal performance (e.g. financial performance, competitive balance). For example, if a governing body wants to minimize head injuries, what rule component "levers" does it manipulate? Our findings suggest the organization could, for example, adjust the actions component to constrain behaviors associated with head injuries. However, changes may introduce unforeseen and undesirable increases in other types of injuries (Hanson et al., 2017). It is therefore important to study the wide-ranging implications of changes to rules and their components for organizations, athletes, referees, and fans. To what extent do adjustments successfully address the original goal or intent (e.g. reducing injuries, easing officiating)? For example, scholars could investigate whether altering the sanctions component of rules is more effective than expanding the times component at reducing injuries. These lines of inquiry can deepen the theoretical and practical understanding of how sport organizations change rules to pursue multiple, potentially conflicting, goals, and impact on various stakeholders.

Future research could also examine what is driving the expanding scope of rules and sequence of rule evolution, and whether these patterns generalize to other sports. Studies might explore, systematically, whether and how macro-level institutional factors (e.g. professionalization, regulation, new knowledge, public pressure) and internal factors (e.g. leadership, decision-making, crises) are contributing to the overall growth in rules in the NFL. Further, research should examine whether the scope of rules is also expanding in highly institutionalized international sports, such as soccer and rugby (governed by FIFA and World Rugby). Scholars could also investigate the pattern of expansion, elaboration, and reduction. It is unclear if the sequence is one of necessity or convention. Can rule managers make the process of iterating rules more efficient? Doing so may allow sport organizations to reallocate time and energy to other tasks. Or perhaps the sequence reflects an organizational learning process that is consistent across different types of rules and sport organizations. Future work could explore these dynamics, connecting our findings to research on processes of organizational learning and adaptation in relation to institutional forces (Argote et al., 2021; Greve & Teh, 2018).

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